

Chapter 14 — Guṇa-Traya Yoga

गुणत्रयविभागयोगः : गुणत्रयविभागयोगम्

"The Three Guṇas" · 27 verses · The three forces that weave all of nature

Chapter 14 introduces the great Sāṅkhya analysis of nature into three **guṇas** — strands, qualities, modes:

- **sattva** — purity, light, harmony, knowing
- **rajas** — activity, passion, restlessness, desire
- **tamas** — inertia, dullness, darkness, delusion

These three are always mixing in different proportions in every person, every moment, every action. They bind the soul like three different kinds of rope. **The goal is not to maximize one but to transcend all three** — to become *guṇātīta*, beyond the guṇas. And the chapter ends with the great promise: **steady devotion (bhakti) is what carries you across them.**

Essential verses of Chapter 14

BG 14.5 The three guṇas — born of prakṛti — bind the embodied Self

सत्त्वं रजस्तम इति गुणाः प्रकृतिसम्भवाः ।

निबध्नन्ति महाबाहो देहे देहिनमव्ययम् ॥ १४.५ ॥

సత్త్వం రజస్తమ ఇతి గుణాః ప్రకృతిసంభవాః ।

నిబద్ధంతి మహాబాహో దేహే దేహినమవ్యయమ్ ॥ ౧౪.౫ ॥

sattvaṁ rajas tama iti guṇāḥ prakṛti-sambhavāḥ |

nibadhnanti mahā-bāho dehe dehinam avyayam |

"Sattva, rajas, and tamas — these three guṇas, born of prakṛti, bind the imperishable Self in the body, O mighty-armed one."

Word-by-Word — 14.5 (the three guṇas bind the Self)

IAST	सत्त्वं रजस्तम	प्रकृतिसम्भवाः	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
<i>sattvam</i>	सत्त्वं	सत्त्वं	SAT-tvam	sattva — purity, lightness, harmony
<i>rajaḥ</i>	रजः	रजः	RA-jah	rajas — passion, activity, restlessness
<i>tamaḥ</i>	तमः	तमः	TA-mah	tamas — inertia, dullness, darkness
<i>iti guṇāḥ</i>	इति गुणाः	इति गुणाः	I-ti GU-naah	thus, the qualities (strands)
<i>prakṛti-sambhavāḥ</i>	प्रकृतिसम्भवाः	प्रकृतिसंभवः	pra-KRI-ti-sam-BHA-vaah	born of / arising from prakṛti (nature)
<i>nibadhnanti</i>	निबध्नन्ति	निबध्नन्ति	ni-BADH-nan-ti	they bind
<i>mahā-bāho</i>	महाबाहो	महाबाहो	ma-haa-BAA-ho	O mighty-armed (Arjuna)
<i>dehe</i>	देहे	देहे	DE-he	in the body
<i>dehinam</i>	देहिनम्	देहिनम्	DE-hi-nam	the embodied (Self)
<i>avyayam</i>	अव्ययम्	अव्ययम्	av-YA-yam	imperishable

